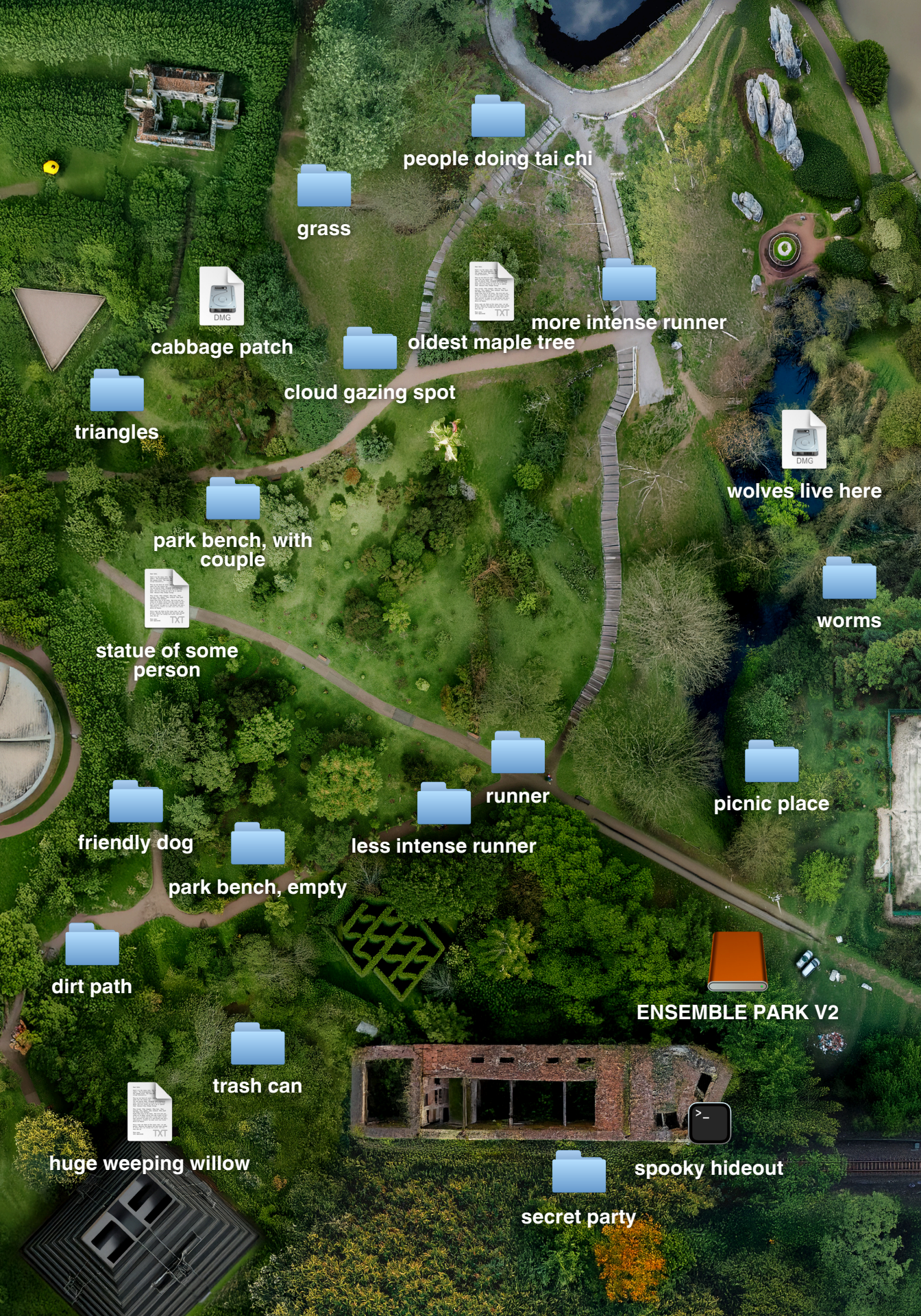

people doing tai chi
grass
cabbage patch
oldest maple tree
more intense runner
cloud gazing spot
triangles
wolves live here
park bench, with couple
worms
statue of some person
runner
picnic place
friendly dog
less intense runner
park bench, empty
dirt path
ENSEMBLE PARK V2
trash can
huge weeping willow
spooky hideout
secret party

ENSEMBLE
Park

THIS IS THE ONLINE EDITION.

THE PRINT EDITION CONTAINS AN EXTRA 25 PAGES
OF INTERVIEWS WITH THE AUTHORS.

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A farmer a river furrow a wet ribbon between, a man a carrier man, a boatman. Teeth once a wolf howl waiting, a bleating bundle a goat nibbler's heart, a green sphere, leafed prize, still cabbage and still food, the ferry shells for a carry, simple rules inscribed across a hull

Now the bank, the mire, the farming man, the burdens panting, the always pointless panting, the goat, the shuddering, the damn cabbage. Maybe cross, must cross. Never mind, a thing at a time. No matter

First the bleating bundle, goat over goat across, goat life in the grass, nibbling toward the ferry mark. The teeth danger fur travels, wolf across wolf next, wolf toward goat as the boatman watches and waits

The fur afield now. Distant barren stretch of grey on grey. Farmer stands, or leans. Does it matter? Hands hang, mud clings. The vessel, the decree, unwritten. Fang finds fleece, unsupervised. Fleece finds foliage likewise

A wolf a fur quickness a tooth line in sudden shadow. A goat is a white pull, a nibbling insistence, a fenced feeling. Cabbage green layers wound tight, a cool right roundness over quiet center, arriving and now across

Farmer boat wolf howl waiting, goat nibbler heart and cabbage ball. All across on, all on the far on, the watery divide behind, puzzling puzzled, the crossing done, all there yes, all there huddled

Can today's massively hyped LLMs create accurate world models, either hypothetical (as in games or puzzles) or actual (as in the world we inhabit)? One rainy afternoon in London I asked the newly released *Gemini 2.5* to try some of the word problems that had stumped its predecessors. One of these was a version of the *River Crossing Puzzle*:

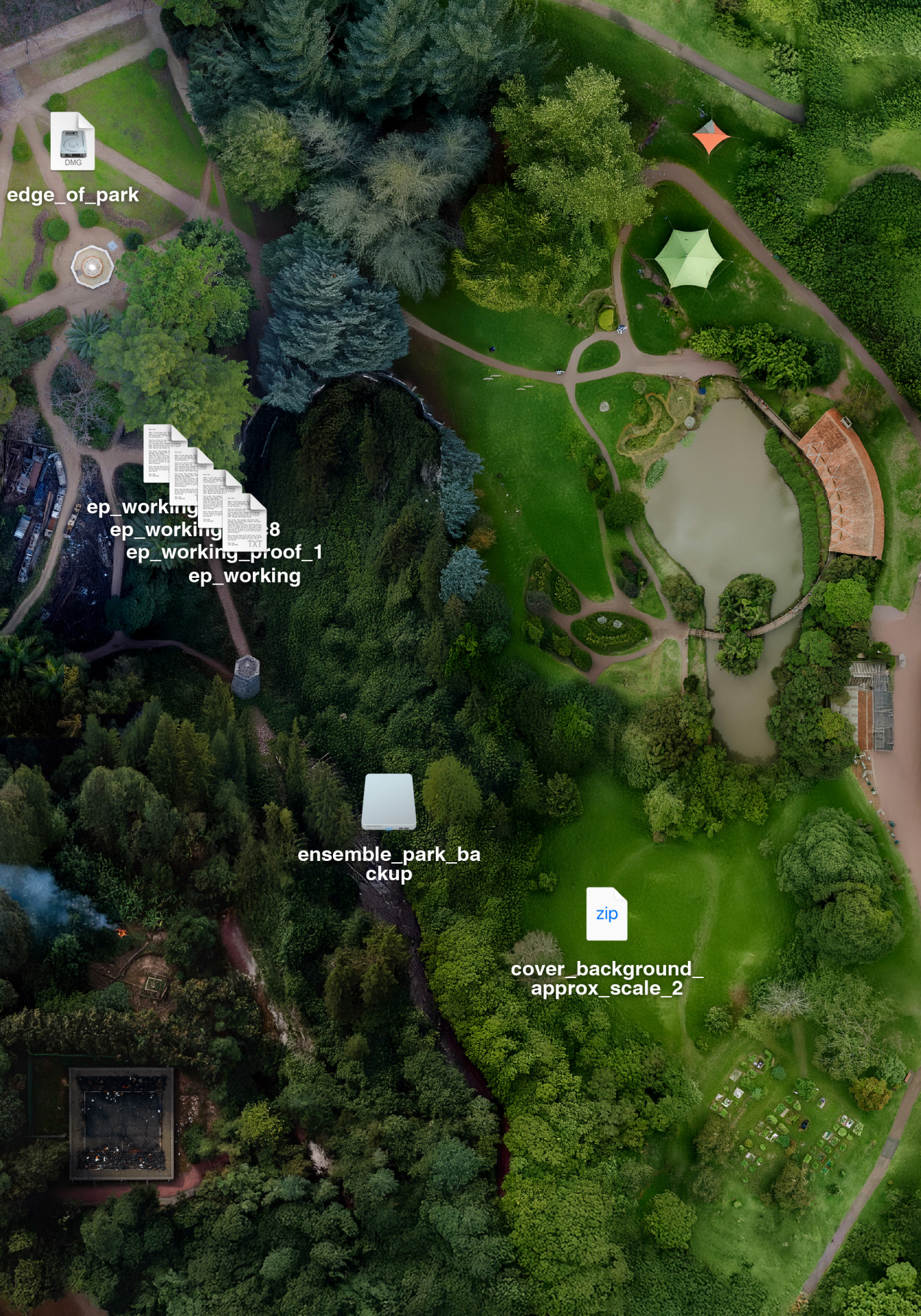
> *A farmer is on one side of a river with a wolf, a goat, and a cabbage. When crossing the river in a boat, she can only take one item with her at a time. The wolf will eat the goat if left alone together, and the goat will eat the cabbage if left alone together. How can the farmer transport the goat across the river without it being eaten?*

While humans quickly realize that the farmer can take the goat directly across and solve the puzzle in a single step, Gemini, like the models before it, could not. It iterated instead over a number of convoluted and bloody attempts before generating a highly complex but failing sequence. But the obsessive nature of its so-called "chain-of-thought" reasoning was interesting; a probing, insistent, broken stream-of-consciousness that brought to mind Stein's *Tender Buttons* or Beckett's obsessive combinatoric passages in *Watt*. When I asked the LLM to repeat its failed solution in the voices of Stein and Beckett, I had the raw material that became the piece included here.

Note on the cover:

Aerial photos were found on Pixabay, a stock image site. Adobe Photoshop's built-in AI, Firefly, was used to gradually "extend" these photos until they were knitted together into a continuous map. The generated image was thus conditioned on the real photographs, the prompts given to Firefly (e.g., "aerial drone photograph of path connecting in forest park" or "drone aerial shot of forest fire, smoke, from high above"), and the bits of the map that had already been generated.

This was the work of one person, who then sent the map to the other person. This second person, taking the landscape into account, added folders and other desktop elements.


edge_of_park
ep_working
ep_working_proof_1
ep_working
ensemble_park_backup
zip
cover_background_approx_scale_2